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SECURITY



These are our favorite
cyber books on hacking,
espionage, crypto,
surveillance, and more

Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai, Zack Whittaker

8:00 AM PDT · July 19, 2025

In the last 30 years or so, cybersecurity has gone from being a niche specialty within the larger field of computer science, to an industry estimated to be worth over \$170 billion made of a globe-spanning community of hackers. In turn, the industry's growth and high-profile hacks such as the [2015 Sony breach](#), the [2016 U.S. election hack and leak operations](#), the [Colonial Pipeline ransomware attack](#), and a [seemingly endless list of Chinese government hacks](#) have made cybersecurity and hacking go mainstream.

Pop culture has embraced hackers with hit TV shows like “Mr. Robot,” and movies like “Leave the World Behind.” But perhaps the most prolific medium for cybersecurity stories — both fiction and based on reality — is books.

IMAGE CREDITS: TECHCRUNCH

We have curated our own list of best cybersecurity books, based on the books we have read ourselves, and those that the community suggested on [Mastodon](#) and [Bluesky](#).

This list of books (in no particular order) will be periodically updated.

[“Countdown to Zero Day,” Kim Zetter](#)

The cyberattack coordinated by Israeli and U.S. government hackers known as Stuxnet, which damaged the centrifuges at the Iranian nuclear

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facility in Natanz, is almost certainly *the* most well-known hack in history. Because of its impact, its sophistication, and its sheer boldness, the attack captured the imagination not only of the cybersecurity community, but the larger public as well.

Veteran journalist [Kim Zetter](#) tells the story of Stuxnet by treating the malware like a character to be profiled. To achieve that, Zetter interviews virtually all the main investigators who found the malicious code, analyzed how it worked, and figured out what it did. It's a must read for anyone who works in the cyber field, but it also serves as a great introduction to the world of cybersecurity and cyberespionage for regular folks.

[“Dark Wire,”](#) Joseph Cox

There haven't been any sting operations more daring and expansive than the FBI's Operation Trojan Shield, in which the feds ran a startup called Anom that sold encrypted phones to some of the worst criminals in the world, from high-profile drug smugglers to elusive mobsters.

Those criminals thought they were using communication devices specifically designed to avoid surveillance. In reality, all their supposedly secure messages, pictures, and audio notes were being funneled to the FBI and its international law enforcement partners. [404 Media journalist Joseph Cox](#) masterfully tells the story of Anom, with interviews with the sting operation's masterminds in the FBI, the developers, and workers who ran the startup, as well as the criminals using the devices.

[“The Cuckoo's Egg,”](#) Cliff Stoll

In 1986, astronomer Cliff Stoll was tasked with figuring out a discrepancy of \$0.75 in his lab's

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computer network usage. At this point, the internet was mostly a network for government and academic institutions, and these organizations paid depending on how much time online they spent. Over the next year, Stoll meticulously pulled the threads of what seemed like a minor incident and ended up discovering one of the first-ever recorded cases of government cyberespionage, in this case carried out by Russia's KGB.

Stoll not only solved the mystery, but he also chronicled it and turned it into a gripping spy thriller. It's hard to understate how important this book was. When it came out in 1989, hackers were barely a blip in the public's imagination. "The Cuckoo's Egg" showed young cybersecurity enthusiasts how to investigate a cyber incident, and it showed the wider public that stories about computer spies could be as exciting as those of real-life James Bond-like figures.

"Your Face Belongs to Us," Kashmir Hill

Face recognition has quickly gone from a technology that seemed all-powerful in movies and TV shows — but was actually janky and imprecise in real-life — to an important and relatively accurate tool for law enforcement in its daily operations. Longtime tech reporter [Kashmir Hill](#) tells the history of the technology through the rise of one of the controversial startups that made it mainstream: Clearview AI.

Unlike other books that profile a startup, at least one of Clearview AI's founders partially engaged with Hill in an attempt to tell his own side of the story, but the journalist did a lot of work to fact-check — and in some cases debunk — some of what she heard from her company sources. Hill is the best positioned writer to tell the story of

Clearview AI after first revealing its existence in 2020, which gives the book an engaging first-person narrative in some sections.

“Cult of the Dead Cow,” Joseph Menn

Investigative cyber reporter [Joseph Menn](#) tells the incredible true backstory of the influential Cult of the Dead Cow, one of the oldest hacking supergroups from the '80s and '90s, and how they helped to transform the early internet into what it has become today. The group's members include mainstream names, from tech CEOs and activists, some of whom went on to advise presidents and testify to lawmakers, to the security heroes who [helped to secure much of the world's modern technologies and communications](#).

Menn's book celebrates both what the hackers achieved, built, and broke along the way in the name of bettering cybersecurity, freedom of speech and expression, and privacy rights, and codifies the history of the early internet hacking scene as told by some of the very people who lived it.

“Hack to the Future,” Emily Crose

“Hack to the Future” is an essential read for anyone who wants to understand the incredible and rich history of the hacking world and its many cultures. The book's author, [Emily Crose](#), a hacker and security researcher by trade, covers some of the earliest hacks that were rooted in mischief, through to the modern day, with no detail spared on the decades in between.

This book is deeply researched, well represented, and both part-history and part-celebration of the hacker community that morphed from the curious-minded misfits whistling into a telephone to score

free long-distance calls to becoming a powerful community wielding geopolitical power and featured prominently in mainstream culture.

“Tracers in the Dark,” Andy Greenberg

The concept of cryptocurrency was born in a 2008 white paper published by a mysterious (and still unknown) figure called Satoshi Nakamoto. That laid the foundation for Bitcoin, and now, almost 20 years later, crypto has become its own industry and embedded itself in the global financial system. Crypto is also very popular among hackers, from low-level scammers, to sophisticated North Korean government spies and thieves.

In this book, Wired’s [Andy Greenberg](#) details a series of high-profile investigations that relied on following the digital money through the blockchain. Featuring interviews with the investigators who worked on these cases, Greenberg tells the behind-the-scenes of the takedown of the pioneering dark web marketplace Silk Road, as well as the operations against dark web hacking marketplaces (Alpha Bay), and the “world’s largest” child sexual abuse website called [“Welcome to Video.”](#)

“Dark Mirror,” Barton Gellman

Over a decade ago, former NSA contractor Edward Snowden blew wide open the vast scale of the U.S. government’s global surveillance operations by leaking thousands of top secret files to a handful of journalists. One of those journalists was [Barton Gellman](#), a then-Washington Post reporter who later chronicled in his book “Dark Mirror” the inside story of Snowden’s initial outreach and the process

of verifying and reporting the cache of classified government files provided by the whistleblower.

From secretly tapping the private fiber optic cables connecting the data centers of some of the world's biggest companies, to the covert snooping on lawmakers and world leaders, the files detailed how the National Security Agency and its global allies were capable of spying on almost anyone in the world. "Dark Mirror" isn't just a look back at a time in history, but a first-person account of how Gellman investigated, reported, and broke new ground on some of the most influential and important journalism of the 21st century, and should be required reading for all cyber journalists.

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Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai

Senior Reporter, Cybersecurity | [X](#) [🦋](#) [@](#)

Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai is a Senior Writer at TechCrunch, where he covers hacking, cybersecurity,...

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Zack Whittaker

Security Editor | [🦋](#) [@](#) [🏠](#)

Zack Whittaker is the security editor at TechCrunch. He can be reached via encrypted message at...

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Lorenzo Franceschi-
Bicchierai

— 8:11 AM PST · December 6,
2023

U.S. cybersecurity agency CISA has warned that unknown hackers broke into the servers of a federal government agency by taking advantage of a previously known vulnerability in software that no longer receives updates — meaning the agency couldn't have patched it even if it wanted to.

On Tuesday, [CISA released an advisory](#) detailing two separate cyberattacks on an unnamed federal government agency. The hackers attacked the agency in June and July by targeting public-facing servers that were running outdated or end-of-life

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Adobe ColdFusion software, used for building web applications.

End-of-life software means that the developer has announced publicly it will no longer be supported or receive further software or security updates. Running end-of-life software is by definition risky because it cannot be patched, exposing the organization who runs the software to cyberattacks.

Contact Us

Do you have more information about these attacks? Or other attacks targeting government agencies? We'd love to hear from you. You can contact Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai securely on Signal at +1 917 257 1382, or via Telegram, Keybase and Wire @lorenzofb, or email lorenzo@techcrunch.com. You also can contact TechCrunch via SecureDrop.

CISA said there is no evidence the attackers planted malware or did anything more than looking around in the hacked agency's network.

"Analysis suggests that the malicious activity conducted by the threat actors was a reconnaissance effort to map the broader network," but CISA conceded that it could not confirm if data was exfiltrated from the agency's network.

CISA spokesperson Antonio Soliz declined to comment when asked by TechCrunch for more information on who the agency believes are the hackers responsible for targeting the agency.

In the advisory, CISA said it didn't know if the two cyberattacks were performed by the same hackers.

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In both cyberattacks, Microsoft Defender for Endpoint, Windows' native antivirus software, alerted the agency to the potential exploitation of the Adobe ColdFusion vulnerability and "quarantined" the hackers' activities.

In March, CISA ordered all federal agencies to patch one of the known vulnerabilities in Adobe ColdFusion that were exploited in these attacks, [CVE-2023-26360](#).

UPDATE, December 6, 4:31 p.m. ET: This story was updated to include the no comment from CISA spokesperson.

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Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai

Senior Reporter, Cybersecurity | [X](#) [Twitter](#) [@](#)

Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai is a Senior Writer at TechCrunch, where he covers hacking, cybersecurity,...

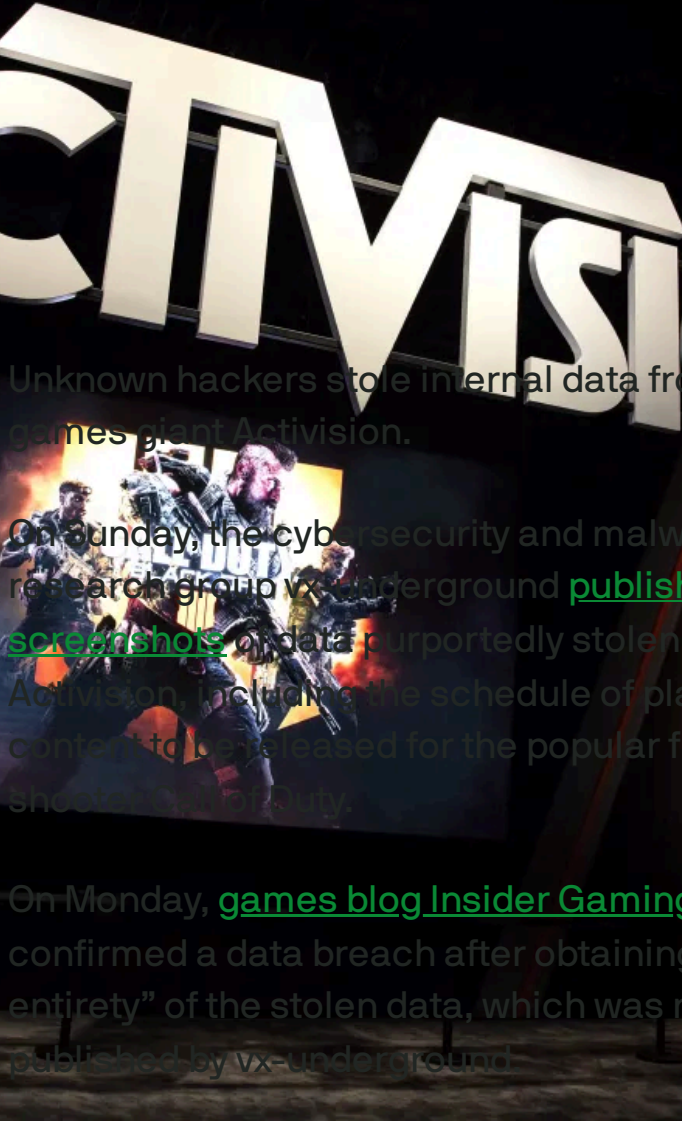
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Hackers steal Activision games and employee data



Unknown hackers stole internal data from the games giant Activision.

On Sunday, the cybersecurity and malware research group vx-underground [published screenshots](#) of data purportedly stolen from Activision, including the schedule of planned content to be released for the popular first-person shooter Call of Duty.

On Monday, [games blog Insider Gaming](#) said it confirmed a data breach after obtaining “the entirety” of the stolen data, which was not published by vx-underground.

According to the site, [hackers stole employee information](#) such as “full names, emails, phone numbers, salaries, places of work, addresses, and more.”

TechCrunch has not been able to confirm the legitimacy of the published data or the details of the breach.

Activision spokesperson Joseph Christinat sent the following statement: “The security of our data is paramount, and we have comprehensive information security protocols in place to ensure its confidentiality. On December 4, 2022, our information security team swiftly addressed an SMS phishing attempt and quickly resolved it. Following a thorough investigation, we determined

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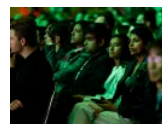
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that no sensitive employee data, game code, or player data was accessed.”

In [a tweet](#), vx-underground wrote that Activision was breached on December 4, after hackers “successfully phished a privileged user on the network.”

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“Also worth noting that the Threat Actor(s) did attempt to phish other employees. Other employees did not fall for the phish. However, it

appears they did not report the security incident to the Activision Information Security Team,” vx-underground wrote.

Activision is just the latest victim in a series of hacks against video game companies.

In January, [Riot Games disclosed a breach](#) in which hackers accessed the company’s “development environment,” allowing them to steal source code of the popular games League of Legends and Teamfight Tactics, as well as the source code for the company’s legacy anti-cheat system.

Earlier in September, hackers [published unreleased footage](#) from the upcoming and much anticipated Grand Theft Auto VI. At the time, the game-maker Rockstar Games admitted that hackers had been able to get their hands on “confidential information from our systems, including early development footage from the next Grand Theft Auto.”

And throughout 2022, a hacking group known as Oktapus (or Scattered Spider) [targeted at least 130 companies](#), according to cybersecurity firm Group-IB. The group gained notoriety for [hacking the cloud communications company Twilio](#), which provides other companies services such as sending automated text messages to their users. Among the around 130 companies targeted there were several game makers, including Riot Games and Epic Games.

Do you have more information about this data breach? We’d love to hear from you. From a non-work device, you can contact Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai securely on Signal at +1 917 257 1382, or via Wickr, Telegram and Wire @lorenzofb, or email lorenzo@techcrunch.com. You can also contact TechCrunch via [SecureDrop](#).

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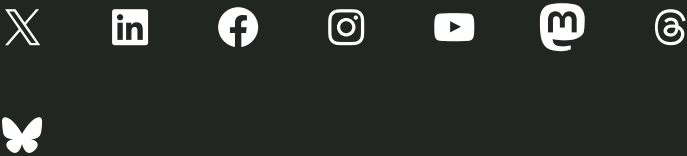


Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai
Senior Reporter, Cybersecurity | [X](#) [🦋](#) [m](#)

Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai is a Senior Writer at TechCrunch, where he covers hacking, cybersecurity,...

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